

Play It Again, Sam

A ROMANTIC COMEDY
IN THREE ACTS

By Woody Allen



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PLAY IT AGAIN, SAM was first pres
Merrick, in association with Jack Rolli
Joffe, at the Broadhurst Theatre, N.Y.C.,
The setting was by William Ritman, co
Roth, and lighting by Martin Aronstein.
play was Joseph Hardy.

CAST

(In Order of Appearance)

ALLAN FELIX	LA
NANCY	Kat
BOGEY	Pe
DICK CHRISTIE	P
LINDA CHRISTIE	Ant
SHARON	Barb
SHARON LAKE	D
GINA	J
VANESSA	Cyn
GO-GO GIRL	Lee
INTELLECTUAL GIRL	Bar
BARBARA	Barbara

house to 1/2
house out
Alan enter

Sound Forestry
at
Sound on

Play It Again, Sam

Light up

ACT ONE

SCENE 1

The house *LIGHTS DIM* and we hear the voices of *Humphrey Bogart and Mary Astor* in a scene from "The Maltese Falcon." It is the scene at the end where Bogart is going to turn her in despite the fact he loves her and she can't believe it. Presently the *CURTAIN* rises on *ALLAN FELIX*, watching the movie on his TV set in the living room of his apartment on 10th Street, between Fifth and Sixth Avenues, in New York City. The living room is one of three rooms, the other two being a small but adequate bedroom and small but adequate kitchen, both of which are offstage in opposite directions. U. C. there is a door which is the entrance to the apartment and which opens right in on the living room. The living room itself is a reasonably spacious room, typical of the type found in old village brownstones; cheery with good-sized windows that overlook a tree-lined block from the second floor. It has a wood-burning fireplace and is furnished with a youthful warmth that includes books and records, a large photo of Bogart, comfortable chairs and an inviting sofa. It is an apartment that rents for about a hundred and sixty-five dollars a month and has been furnished and lived in for the past two years by the *Felices*, a young married couple. *ALLAN FELIX* is a slight, bespectacled young man of about twenty-eight or nine who looks as if he just stepped out of a *Jules*

Feiffer cartoon. He earns a decent living as a writer of articles and reviews, some literary but mostly cinematic, as he is a film buff, for a little intellectual film magazine. He daydreams of someday doing something important in either literature or film. ALLAN daydreams a lot—in fact, his mind is a hyperactive mass of preposterously neurotic contradictions that make the world a little too much for him. He is nervous, shy, insecure, and has been in and out of psychotherapy for years.

At rise ALLAN is alone in the swivel chair watching "The Maltese Falcon" on a tiny TV which sits on the D. R. hassock. The film is in the final sequence wherein Bogey tells Mary Astor that he is going to turn her in. The sound track precedes the Curtain for a line or two. . . . He watches a bit after the curtain is up, sighs, crosses to the set and turns it off.

ALLAN. How does he do it? What's the secret? It's the movies that's the secret. Maybe if I took two more aspirin I'd feel better. That's 2—4—6 aspirin. *(He picks up empty aspirin bottle on coffee table.)* I'm turning into an aspirin junkie. Next thing you know I'll be boiling the cotton at the top of the bottle to get the extra. What's the matter with me—why can't I relax? I never should have signed those papers. *(He sits on the swivel chair hassock.)* Let her take me to court. Two years of marriage down the drain . . . like that. . . . I couldn't believe it when she told me two weeks ago. She was like a stranger, not like my wife, like a total stranger.

(DREAM LIGHT in the office area. NANCY appears from U. R. C. slot, in wrapper, drying her hair with a towel, and crosses to D. R. end of railing on platform.)

NANCY. I don't want any alimony. You can have everything. I just want out.

ALLAN. Can't we discuss it?

NANCY. We've discussed it fifty times. It's no use.

ALLAN. Why?

NANCY. I don't know. I can't stand the marriage. I don't find you fun. I feel you suffocate me. I don't feel any rapport with you, and I don't dig you physically. For God's sake don't take it personal! (Exits D. R. slot,

LIGHT FADES.)

ALLAN. (~~Rises~~ *paces* L. and R.) Oh, I won't take it personal. I'll just kill myself, that's all. If only I knew where my damn analyst was vacationing. Where do they go every August? They leave the city. Every summer New York is full of people who are crazy till Labor Day. And so what? What if I reach him? No matter what I say he tells me it's a sexual problem. Isn't that silly? How can there be a sexual problem? We weren't even having relations. Well, once in a while. But she used to watch television during it . . . and change channels with the remote control switch. (*Sits swivel hassock.*) What's the matter with me? Why can't I be cool? What's the secret?

spot light
(DREAM LIGHT in U. L. area. BOGART appears from U. L. slot in trench coat.)

BOGART. There's no secret, kid. Dames are simple. I never met one who didn't understand a slap in the mouth or a slug from a forty-five.

ALLAN. I could never hit Nancy. It's not that type of relationship.

BOGART. (*Crosses* D. L.) Relationship? Where'd you learn that word? From one of those Park Avenue head-shrinkers?

ALLAN. I'm not like you. At the end of "Casablanca," when you lost Ingrid Bergman, weren't you crushed?

BOGART. (*Crosses* U. L. *steps.*) Nothing that a little bourbon and soda wouldn't fix.

ALLAN. See, I don't drink. My body will not tolerate alcohol.

PLAY IT AGAIN, SAM

ACT I

BOGART. Take my advice and forget this fancy relationship stuff. The world is full of dames. All you got to do is whistle. (BOGART exits U. R. slot, DREAM LIGHT FADES.)

ALLAN. (Pacing.) He's right. You give 'em an inch and they step all over you. Why can't I develop that attitude? Nothing a little bourbon and soda couldn't heal. I have one thimbleful of bourbon, I run out and get tattooed. On the other hand, why should a divorce bother me so? What the hell—maybe I'm better off without her. Why not? I'm young . . . I'm healthy . . . I got a good job . . . this could be an opportunity to step out a little . . . if she can swing, so can I. I'll get broads up here like you wouldn't believe. I'll turn this place into a night club. Swingers, freaks, nymphomaniacs . . . salesgirls from Paraphernalia. . . . She didn't want me—I'm not going to push myself on her. (Sits swivel.) I couldn't believe the things she said to me the day she left.

(DREAM LIGHT in office area. NANCY enters from D. R. slot to R. end of railing on platform, with bag, gloves, and scarf.)

NANCY. I want a new life. I want to go ^{dancing} discothequeing and skiing and to the beach. I want to drive through Europe on a motorcycle. All we ever do is see movies.

ALLAN. I write for a film magazine, they send me. Besides I happen to like movies.

NANCY. You like movies because you're one of life's great watchers. I'm not like that. I'm a doer. I want to participate. I want to laugh. We never laugh together.

ALLAN. How can you say that? I don't know about you, but I'm constantly laughing—I chuckle, I giggle, I guffaw occasionally. Besides, why didn't any of this come up while we were dating?

NANCY. Things were different—you were more aggressive.

ALLAN. Everybody is during courtship. It's only

natural. You try and impress the other person. You can't expect me to keep up that level of charm. I'd have a heart attack.

NANCY. *Goodbye, Allan. My lawyer will call your lawyer.*

ALLAN. I don't have a lawyer . . . have him call my doctor. (NANCY exits U. R. C. slot, DREAM LIGHT FADES. ALLAN paces.) She thinks she's some hot stuff.

She's no swinger. She's a product of the City College cafeteria. Next thing you know she'll be smoking pot—she'll think it's hip. I smoked pot once. Had a bad reaction . . . tried to take my pants off over my head. It's 'cause I'm guilty. I'm always so guilty over everything. She leaves me and I'm worried how she'll make out. (DOOR BUZZER sounds.) There's Dick and Linda. Thank God for Dick. He's my best friend, but I must not use him as a crutch. (BUZZ.) I'll use him as a crutch. (Opens door.)

(DICK, nice-looking young executive type, and his lovely wife LINDA, enter.)

DICK. (Along railing.) Allan, are you all right?

LINDA. (Closes door; crosses to end of railing.) Oh, you poor thing.

DICK. Why didn't you call us as soon as she left?

ALLAN. (Off platform, steps R.) I didn't want to bother you.

DICK. Not bother us! For God's sake, what are friends for?

LINDA. What reason did she give for wanting a divorce?

ALLAN. (To swivel, then sits corner bench.) She wants to laugh. She doesn't laugh enough. Insufficient laughter, that's grounds for divorce. And skiing—she wants to go skiing. She wants to ski down a mountain laughing like an idiot.

DICK. Just let me call my office and let them know where I am. I rushed right out of a business meeting the minute you called. They must've thought I was crazy.

LINDA. (*Purse on bench.*) Have you heard from her?

ALLAN. I heard from the firm of Schulman and Weiss, they had me sign some papers, and Nancy went to Mexico. It's funny. We went to Mexico on our honeymoon. Spent the entire two weeks in bed. I had dysentery.

(*During above, and following speeches, LINDA puts books from floor by coffee table on shelf above bar; puts magazines from sofa corner on table behind sofa; gets mug from bar, sweater from L. end of sofa, TV trays and aspirin bottle from coffee table, and in general cleans up the place.*)

DICK. (*On phone.*) Hello, George? Did they agree to the terms? Oh hell. Well, if we blow it we blow it.

LINDA. Don't you cook anything but TV dinners?

ALLAN. Who cooks 'em? I suck 'em frozen.

DICK. Let me tell you where you can reach me. I'll be at Gramercy 7-9205 for a while, then I'll be at Murray Hill 5-4774 for fifteen minutes, then I'll be at Templeton 8-5548, then I'll be home, that's LE 5-8343. Right, George.

LINDA. There's a phone booth on the corner—you want me to run down and get the number, you'll be passing it. (*Exits kitchen.*)

DICK. I'm sorry, Allan.

ALLAN. She wants to be a swinger. All of a sudden married life is no good.

DICK. Don't get all worked up.

(*LINDA enters from kitchen with paper toweling, which she puts on desk. Then she puts the papers from the floor around the wastebasket into the wastebasket, and the wastebasket under the desk. Then she takes the robe off the D. R. corner of the railing and the towel and T shirt off the back of the desk chair.*)

ALLAN. I gave her a home with affection and security.

This was a little girl I found waiting on tables at the Hip Bagel. I used to come in every night and overtip her. A dollar-fifty on a thirty-five-cent check! (*LINDA takes robe off railing, towel and T shirt off desk chair.*)

DICK. Nancy was impulsive. We all knew that about her.

ALLAN. She didn't leave impulsively. She talked about it for months. I just couldn't believe she'd go through with it. I'm such a naive jerk. I'm lying in bed with her and she's looking up lawyers in the yellow pages.

DICK. It's good you found out now. You're young. You can make new lives. (*LINDA takes things into bedroom.*)

ALLAN. Young? I'm 29. The height of my sexual potency was ten years ago.

DICK. Look at the bright side. You're free. You'll go out. You'll meet exciting new girls, you'll flirt, there'll be parties, you'll have affairs with married women, sexual relations with girls of every race, creed, and color. (*LINDA comes out of bedroom, down R. steps, picks up plastic pillow, puts on bench.*)

ALLAN. Ah, you get tired of that. Besides those things never happen to me. I managed to fool one girl into loving me and now she's gone.

DICK. See how he downgrades himself? Don't you think there are plenty of women in the world who would find him attractive?

LINDA. Huh? . . . Oh-er . . . of course.

DICK. (*Sits sofa.*) The world is full of eligible women.

ALLAN. Not like Nancy. She was a lovely thing. I used to lie in bed at night and watch her sleep. Once in a while she'd wake up and see me. She'd let out a scream.

LINDA. He really loved her. I feel like crying.

DICK. Why do you feel like crying? A man makes an investment—it doesn't pay off.

LINDA. Could I get an aspirin? I'm getting a little headache.

DICK. He's having a breakdown and you're getting sick.

LINDA. Don't get upset.

DICK. I'm not getting upset. I had a very rough day today.

ALLAN. You want an aspirin?

DICK. No.

ALLAN. I ate all the aspirins. What about Darvan?

LINDA. That's okay. My analyst once suggested Darvan when I had migraines.

ALLAN. I used to get migraines but my analyst cured me. Now I get tremendous cold sores.

LINDA. I still do. Big ugly ones—from tension.

ALLAN. I don't think analysis can help me. I may need a lobotomy.

LINDA. With mine on vacation I feel paralyzed.

DICK. The two of you should get married and move into a hospital.

ALLAN. You want a Fresca with your Darvan?

LINDA. Unless you have apple juice.

ALLAN. Oh, apple juice and Darvan are fantastic together.

LINDA. Have you ever had Librium and tomato juice?

ALLAN. I haven't personally but another neurotic tells me they're unbelievable.

DICK. Could I get a Coke with nothing in it?

take aspirin to bed
(ALLAN exits to bedroom; LINDA puts papers in hall.)

LINDA. He's suffering for her so. It's kind of sweet in a way. Would you suffer for me like that?

DICK. Sure I'd suffer, but I wouldn't go crazy. You're like him. The two of you can get emotionally wrapped up in a weather report.

LINDA. He never should have married Nancy.

DICK. He never mentioned anything. I thought they were getting along.

LINDA. That's because you're so busy all the time. You never see what's going on around you. Didn't you think it was strange he was married and yet he still couldn't get a date for New Year's Eve?

DICK. Why are you getting so overwrought?

LINDA. These things upset me. I'm experiencing a wave of insecurity.

DICK. You're experiencing a wave of insecurity? May I tell you what happened to me today? I bought 100 acres of land in Florida this morning. It turns out ninety-eight of them have quicksand. My syndicate wanted to build a golf course. Now what? The only thing we can do is build a three-hole golf course with the biggest sand trap in the world. Why did this have to come up when I'm on the verge of a million things?

LINDA. You're always on the verge of a million things.

DICK. I can't help it. That's what I do, Linda. I look for openings, I keep on my toes, I play the market, I make brilliant deals like this quicksand thing.

155 LINDA. Dick, you're doing brilliantly. You're only ~~twenty-nine~~ years old and you've already filed for bankruptcy twice.

DICK. Oh, come on, darling, don't get upset. Could I be any more crazy about you? Jesus, I tell him to take it easy. . . . If I was in his shoes I'd go nuts. Now come on, we've got to get him over this.

LINDA. If I knew a nice girl for him.

DICK. You know models. There must be somebody in your agency.

LINDA. Not that many single ones.

DICK. What about Carol?

LINDA. Engaged.

DICK. And Doreen?

LINDA. She's living with a priest.

DICK. (*Brainstorm.*) What about Zorita? That model at Don's party?

LINDA. For Allan? My God, she'd eat him alive. There'd be nothing left but his glasses. No, this is going to be a little problem.

ALLAN. (*Enters with pills and drinks.*) Y'know I'm glad you two came over. I'm feeling a little better.

DICK. Listen, Allan, Linda and I are going out for

dinner tonight. We'll invite some nice girl, and the four of us will go together.

ALLAN. Oh no, I don't think so.

DICK. Come on, you've got to get out of the house.

ALLAN. I haven't looked at another woman in ^{two} years. I'm out of practice. When I was in practice I was out of practice.

DICK. Come on, Allan. You've invested your emotions in a losing stock, it was wiped out, dropped off the board. What do you do? You reinvest . . . maybe in a more stable stock . . . something with long-term growth possibilities.

ALLAN. Who are you going to fix me up with—Merrill, Lynch, Pierce, Fenner, and Smith?

DICK. Come on, Allan, shape up.

ALLAN. A pretty girl? Because she'd have to be damn good to do anything for my morale at all.

DICK. Who can we get for him?

ALLAN. You mean you don't even have anybody in mind?

DICK. We've got several people in mind.

LINDA. What kind do you like?

DICK. He likes neurotics.

ALLAN. I like blondes. Little blondes with long hair and short skirts with big chests and boots and bright and witty, and perceptive.

DICK. Don't set yourself ridiculous standards.

LINDA. She must be beautiful? With long hair and a big bust?

ALLAN. Oh—and a good behind. Something I can sink my teeth into.

DICK. He was always very fussy.

ALLAN. That's right, but look at the result.

DICK. That's right, you never went out.

LINDA. Sally Keller is blond and has a good-sized chest.

ALLAN. What's good-sized?

LINDA. (*Makes gesture with hands.*) I don't know—like this.

DICK. She's not the brightest girl in the world.

ALLAN. What does she do?

LINDA. She dances in a cage at a ^{club}discotheque.

ALLAN. Forget it.

DICK. Come on, you might even be able to get her into bed.

ALLAN. Into bed! With my luck, I wouldn't be able to get her into a chair.

LINDA. Well, the girls that look the way you want them to don't usually have great minds.

DICK. I don't know why we're making such a fuss over a little pleasant dinner companionship.

ALLAN. I don't even want that. I'm still too attached to Nancy.

DICK. Allan, forget Nancy. She's gone.

ALLAN. That's true. She wanted to be free to swing.

DICK. Come on, honey, think of someone.

ALLAN. I can just picture what she's been up to.

NANCY. (*Enters.*) Oh, Jeffrey, take me in your arms, hold me. To think that we two could meet here in a little town like Juarez, you divorcing Celia, me getting rid of what's-his-name. It's such a pleasure to be made love to by a tall, strong, handsome, blond, blue-eyed man. (*Exit.*)

ALLAN. We're divorced two weeks, she's dating a Nazi.

LINDA. Hey, what about Sharon?

DICK. (*It strikes him.*) What about Sharon?

ALLAN. I like the name.

LINDA. Sharon Lake. She works for Jack Edelman the photographer. She's his assistant.

DICK. She's a bright girl and very cute.

ALLAN. Okay. Let's go.

DICK. (*To LINDA.*) Call her.

LINDA. (*Goes to phone.*) Perfect.

ALLAN. (*Beginning to falter.*) What are you going to tell her?

LINDA. (*Dials.*) I'm going to see if she's free for dinner.

ALLAN. (*Getting panicky.*) Don't tell her anything

Light up

Light
Pades

about the divorce. Maybe you better tell her my wife's dead.

DICK. Leave it to us.

ALLAN. I don't know if we should go through with this. *(Begins pacing.)* The old tension is setting in. My stomach is jumping.

LINDA. *(Into phone.)* Sharon Lake please. Linda Christie.

ALLAN. *(Puts hands up to ears, prowls, nervously blocking out sound.)* I don't want to hear this. La-ummmmm-de-ummmmmmmmmmm . . .

LINDA. Sharon? Hi. Linda. How are you? Good. Listen—

ALLAN. Ummmm-ummmmmmm . . .

LINDA. Dick and I are having dinner with a friend tonight and we thought you might want to join us.

ALLAN. Ummmm-ummmmmmm . . .

LINDA. No, that's nothing. We have the radio on. *(Beckons to DICK to help. He silences ALLAN.)* Allan Felix. You don't know him. He's a friend of Dick's.

ALLAN. *(Prompting.)* Attractive. A writer. A widow—widower—my wife died in a mine shaft explosion—

LINDA. He's a lot of fun. I think you'll like him.

ALLAN. Listen, if she doesn't want to—forget it. I don't need this aggravation.

LINDA. Okay. We'll pick you up with the car. Eight o'clock. A simple dress, oh sure . . . flats are okay.

ALLAN. Let her wear heels, what am I—Toulouse-Lautrec?

LINDA. Okay. . . . We'll pick you up. Okay. 'Bye. *(Hangs up.)* You're set.

ALLAN. *(Can hardly suppress his excitement.)* I have very mixed feelings. What if I have this chick in bed and Nancy comes in? Hoo-hoo.

DICK. Let's not hope for too much this first night, Allan.

ALLAN. *(To LINDA.)* Did she say anything about me?

LINDA. She doesn't know you. How could she say anything?

ALLAN. You know, you never said I was a widower.

LINDA. (*Takes Coke and Fresca into kitchen.*) I got you the date. You tell her the part about your wife's death.

ALLAN. Ooh, I'm excited.

DICK. (*Dials phone.*) We'll pick Sharon up because she lives two blocks from us and then the three of us will pick you up. See you about ten after eight. I can't stay out late though, I have a business meeting tomorrow morning.

LINDA. (*Comes out of kitchen with four clean glasses—to bar.*) Listen, if there's anything at all you want—if the dishes pile up or if you need a bed made—

DICK. (*Into phone.*) Hello, this is Mr. Christie. I'm leaving the Gramercy number now and proceeding due north to the Murray Hill number.

ALLAN. Let's eat at Tavern on the Green. It's a perfect night to dine out in Central Park.

LINDA. Wonderful, it's so romantic there.

DICK. Besides I think it's going to rain. (*To ALLAN.*) You be all right? (*DICK and LINDA at door.*)

ALLAN. Sure—I'll be fine—I'll shower and douse my body with Canoe. . . . Now I'm kind of looking forward to it. I'm excited.

DICK. Goodbye.

ALLAN. I'm better. . . . (*Closes door, ALLAN's face changes to serious.*) I'm scared.

BLACKOUT

ACT ONE

SCENE 2

Lights up
Allan enters
It is nearly eight that night. ALLAN emerges from the bedroom, tie around his neck, and goes to the mirror over the bar. He is a mixture of anticipatory excitement, guilt, and nerves as he tries to get his hair to fall satisfactorily.

ALLAN. I cannot get my damn hair to stay down . . . this hot weather is murder on it. I'm not a bad-looking guy . . . chin's a little weak . . . what the hell . . . she shouldn't be disappointed. What does she expect? Rock Hudson? I'm a normal decent-looking guy . . . maybe slightly below normal. I wish she'd seen me before. . . . I hate to be there on a blind date when the girl sets eyes on me. What if she looks at me and laughs or screams? Will you relax! Has a girl ever once reacted by laughing or screaming? Once. That little coed from Brooklyn College came to the door, saw me, and passed out . . . but she was weak from dieting. What the hell . . . Bogart was short . . . didn't bother anybody.

Spot
BOGART. (*Appearing at the archway up R. C.*) You're starting off on the wrong foot, kid.

ALLAN. Negative you mean?

BOGART. Sure. You're letting her get the best of you before the game starts. What's that stuff you were putting on your face?

ALLAN. Canoe. It's an after-shave lotion.

BOGART. And the other stuff?

ALLAN. That was Mennen Spray Deodorant, Lavoris, and Johnson and Johnson Baby Powder.

BOGART. For Christ's sake, you're going to smell like a French cat house.

ALLAN. I need them.

BOGART. Why? You ashamed to sweat?

ALLAN. I want to make an impression.

spot out
BOGART. Y'know, kid, somewhere in life you got turned around. It's her job to smell nice for you. And whatever you do, don't tell her you don't drink. She'll think you're a Boy Scout. And don't get nervous—the only bad break you could get is if she turns out to be a virgin or a cop. (*Exits U. L. slot.*)

ALLAN. With my luck she'll turn out to be both. He's right. A lot of girls get turned on by a masculine earthy quality. I shouldn't have put so much Binaca under my arms. I want to create a good subliminal impression without being too pushy. Hey, I better memorize some photography terms, if she's a photographer's assistant. (*Crosses to the magazine rack D. R. and pulls out a magazine, crossing back to coffee table as he reads.*) "Not only is there a great qualitative difference between my Nikon and my other cameras," says ace photographer Greg Barnett, "but my Nikon is built sturdy enough to withstand the throwing around I give it when the outdoor shooting gets rough." (*Drops magazine to coffee table.*) I'm going to charm this girl. Wouldn't it be great if Sharon and I hit it off at first sight? Sure, why not? They say dames are simple. I never met one who didn't respond to a slap in the mouth or a slug from a forty-five. C'mere, Sharon.

Dream light
sand up
(*DREAM SHARON appears from the U. R. C. slot, slightly disheveled . . . no shoes or stockings. "As Time Goes By" plays softly on the piano.*)

SHARON. Oh, Allan, you are fantastic . . . up until tonight, the doctors had said that I was frigid. I want to thank you for proving them wrong.

ALLAN. If you've got any friends with the same problem, bring them around.

SHARON. When Dick and Linda spoke of you, they used terms like genius and brilliant. They never said you were also an animal.

ALLAN. I'm sorry I had to slap you around, sweetheart, but you got hysterical when I said, "No more."

SHARON. Oh, Allan . . . Allan. (*Exits.*)

(*LIGHTS CHANGE, MUSIC FADES, BUZZER SOUNDS simultaneously. SHARON disappears U. L. stol.*)

ALLAN. Yes?

LINDA. (*Off.*) It's Linda.

ALLAN. Linda?

LINDA. I'm alone. (*ALLAN opens the door. LINDA enters with a jar of cocktail nuts in a bag.*) Sharon's with Dick. They're parking. He sent me ahead just to make sure everything's okay.

ALLAN. Everything's fine. . . . I didn't realize it was so late.

LINDA. (*Takes two bowls out of cabinet and puts nuts into each.*) Hey! What did you do? Break a bottle of shaving lotion?

ALLAN. You're kidding! I'm wearing too much?

LINDA. It's a touch strong . . . not terrible. Once we get into the air, you won't even notice it.

ALLAN. (*Crosses bedroom door.*) I just want to set up the place quickly.

LINDA. (*Nut bowl to coffee table.*) The place is fine. We're only going to have a quick drink and go.

ALLAN. (*Taking book from desk shelf to downstage bench.*) A few carefully placed objects will create the proper impression.

LINDA. (*Bowl of nuts to hassock D. R.*) You're not going to leave half-open books around like you're reading them?

ALLAN. Why not? It creates a certain image.

LINDA. You don't need an image. . . .

ALLAN. (*Takes medal from bar drawer.*) I've got just the thing . . . my hundred-yard-dash medal.

LINDA. You're joking! You're not going to leave out a track medal?

ALLAN. (*Puts medal on swivel hassock.*) Why not? I paid twenty dollars for it!

LINDA. Just be yourself. She'll like you.

ALLAN. (*Takes Bartok record from shelf above desk.*) I've got a big decision to make. Do I go with Thelonious Monk or Bartok's String Quartet Number Five?

LINDA. Why don't you put on Thelonious Monk and leave Bartok carelessly strewn about?

ALLAN. (*Puts Bartok against rail on bench.*) Brilliant! That's exactly what I'll do.

LINDA. (*Gets bottles out of bar and puts them on top.*) I've never seen anyone go through so much trouble to impress a date. Particularly such a casual date. If you devoted this much interest and care with Nancy, I don't see why she left you.

ALLAN. (*Finding Monk record on shelf.*) Oh, I did. I used to write her poems. And take her to little candlelight restaurants and order in French and then the waiter would bring all the wrong things.

LINDA. (*At bench corner.*) Maybe if you had leaned across the candlelight and kissed her . . .

ALLAN. I tried, and she'd say—Christ, not here, people are staring. Then once at a great little bistro on Second Avenue, my sleeve caught fire. (*Puts Monk record on phono and plays. LINDA laughs.*) ~~So you laugh at it, it's~~ funny, right? She took it as a symbol of my clumsiness, which I guess it was. (*Door BUZZER sounds. ALLAN snaps to.*) Finesse . . . tremendous poise . . . I'm an absolute master.

LINDA. Right. I'll get the ice. (*Exits to kitchen as ALLAN answers the door. DICK enters with SHARON LAKE, a very nice girl, attractive, but not the sex machine of ALLAN's vision. However, ALLAN is sufficiently impressed to be rendered speechless.*)

DICK. Allan, this is Sharon.

SHARON. Hello.

ALLAN. AH . . . ER . . . (*Stands dumbfounded, hand on door. DICK directs SHARON to living room, thumps door to release ALLAN's hold and closes door.*)

SHARON. (*Sitting L. end of sofa.*) I was just telling

DICK, I have some friends on this block. In the house across the street. Do you know the Gibsons?

ALLAN. . . . The Gibsons? . . . no. . . . (DICK gives ALLAN a push into the room.)

SHARON. Hal and Eleanor Gibson. They're a great couple. He's an interior decorator.

ALLAN. (At sofa.) Oh, really? That's sort of a hobby of mine.

SHARON. (Looking around, not overly impressed.) Oh . . . uh-huh . . .

ALLAN. The key to decorating is to avoid looking like you used a decorator.

DICK. (At railing.) I've got to make one fast call.

LINDA. (Entering from kitchen with water pitcher and ice bucket to bar.) Hi!

SHARON. Hi! . . . Linda?

LINDA. Yes?

SHARON. Are you wearing Jasmine?

LINDA. Me? No. . . . (LINDA and ALLAN realize simultaneously that the pervading scent is from ALLAN.) What are we drinking?

DICK. J and B on the rocks.

SHARON. I'll just have a little Harvey's Bristol Cream, please.

ALLAN. The usual. (LINDA looks at him quizzically.) Bourbon and water. (LINDA to bar. Pours drinks.)

SHARON. Oh . . . a bourbon man.

ALLAN. Yeah, I gotta cut down on it. I'm putting away a quart a day. (Sits sofa R.)

DICK. (On phone.) Hello, this is Mr. Christie. I'm no longer at Lehigh 5-8343. I'll be at . . . What? Did he leave a message? (Sits at the desk to take a few notes.)

LINDA. (Delivering a glass of sherry to SHARON and back to bar.) Sharon did a movie.

ALLAN. Oh?

SHARON. Underground.

ALLAN. A stag film?

SHARON. Underground. You know—very arty sixteen-millimeter.

LINDA. (*Taking drink to DICK at desk and back to bar.*) Allan's interested in cinema.

SHARON. What do you do?

ALLAN. I'm a writer. Nothing major. For *Film Quarterly*. You know—essays, criticism . . . reviews. . . .

SHARON. This film I made got very good reviews. And I got singled out. Of course, I was the only girl in it with nine men.

ALLAN. Oh, really? What was the film called, maybe I saw it?

SHARON. "Gang Bang." They have the raunchiest titles, but it wasn't a bit sexy. . . .

DICK. (*Finished at the desk, he crosses to join SHARON and ALLAN.*) This is ridiculous. I have to get a phone for my car, Volkswagen or not.

ALLAN. Volkswagen! (*Music starts to build.*) *Sandwich*

LINDA. (*Delivering glass to ALLAN.*) You were all out of bourbon, so I made it straight water. (*She joins group, sitting D. L. hassock with her own drink.*) It's so humid. I think it's going to rain.

SHARON. Maybe that's why I have this headache, I get sinus attacks.

ALLAN. Really? You should have them drained. (*BUILD MUSIC.*)

DICK. (*Sits swivel.*) That's why it's silly to go to Tavern on the Green.

SHARON. Do you think you could turn the music down a bit?

(*ALLAN crosses to office area.*)

DICK. What's the point of going to an outdoor restaurant if it's going to rain?

LINDA. You used to like to take me walking in the rain.

ALLAN. I love the rain . . . it washes memories off

the sidewalk of life. . . . (As this purple prose hangs in the air, ALLAN turns to the phonograph where he accidentally ~~knocks~~ the tone arm, causing an ear-splitting SCRATCH. ALL cringe. DICK spins around in the swivel.)

LINDA. Gee . . . you really have a delicate touch.

DICK. (Rising and crossing to D. R. hassock, takes a nut.) Allan's a little tense. He's had a little misfortune with his wife. . . .

SHARON. His WIFE? (ALLAN takes Monk jacket and replaces record, keeping record jacket in his hands.)

LINDA. Dick . . .

DICK. Ex-wife . . . she's gone . . .

ALLAN. She's dead.

SHARON. How awful!

LINDA. Well, no, she's not dead.

ALLAN. Technically not dead . . . but we're not dating.

DICK. She left him.

SHARON. I'm sorry.

DICK. (Crossing to phone.) Why don't I call and make a reservation at the Hong Fat Noodle Company in Chinatown?

LINDA. (Joining DICK.) Here, I have the phone number in my purse.

ALLAN. (Joining SHARON on the sofa, record jacket in hand.) I don't know if you like Thelonious Monk or not, but to me he has a wry, mirthful quality that's not at all accommodating to the casual listener, although his harmonic conceptions are often haunting.

SHARON. You sound like the back of a record jacket. (ALLAN tosses the album back of sofa.) Er . . . have you known Dick and Linda long?

ALLAN. I've known Dick for years. I don't know Linda nearly as well. Dick's a great guy. A little overambitious maybe, but he's always been that way. He's like a kid brother to me. I'm always helping him out of one jam or another. He kind of looks up to me. (Crosses his legs, hooking his toe under the coffee table and tipping it,

scattering nuts and debris. DICK and LINDA rush to set things right. ALLAN backs off in dismay.)

DICK. *(Turning to ALLAN.)* We're all set at the Hong Fat Noodle Company.

ALLAN. Just let me get my sport jacket. *(He limps off to bedroom.)*

SHARON. . . . Is he on anything?

LINDA. Um . . . oh . . . no.

DICK. I'm just going to call my service and tell them where I'll be.

LINDA. *(Clearing up the mess.)* I hope you like Chinese food.

SHARON. Oh, sure. . . . Linda, I've just got to make it an early evening. . . . I've got a terrible day tomorrow.

LINDA. Oh, I'm sorry.

DICK. *(On phone.)* Hello. This is Mr. Christie. If Mr. Milton from the Chase Manhattan Bank calls, I'll be at the Hong Fat Noodle Company in Chinatown. That's Canal 8-6321.

(LINDA hands SHARON photography magazine from the floor. LINDA puts her and SHARON's glass on bar. DICK crosses to LINDA, gives her his glass.)

SHARON. Hey! Look at this! Greg Barnett. You remember Greg? . . . Jack's old partner. . . . *(Reads.)* "There is a great qualitative difference between my Nikon and my other cameras," says ace photographer Gregg Barnett, "but my Nikon is built sturdy enough to withstand the throwing around I give it when the outdoor shooting gets rough." I wonder how much they paid him to say that?

ALLAN. *(Enters from the bedroom, crosses down to SHARON.)* I'm ready! And you've gotta let me order because I'm an expert on Chinese food.

SHARON. Good! I'm starved . . . we had such a rough day today trying to photograph little children.

ALLAN. *(Giving his arm as they start out.)* Oh really?

Photography is a hobby of mine. In fact, I've been having a little trouble with my cameras lately. See, I feel there is a great qualitative difference between my Nikon and my other cameras, but my Nikon is built sturdy enough to withstand the throwing around I give it when . . .

lights out +

CURTAIN

house on
intermission
sound on

house to 1/2
house out

sound out

lights up

ACT TWO

CURTAIN rises on ALLAN. . . . Two weeks later and he has had a pretty discouraging time of it. He is at the sofa, phone on the coffee table, as he thumbs through an old address book.

ALLAN. Mildred Denberg . . . can't even remember her. Marion Drayson . . . she sat behind me in Civics. Toby Kovack . . . yeah . . . I remember her! She was a pushover, with those great legs and those freaky parties. *(Dials.)* Hello? Is this the Kovack residence? Ah . . . how can I get in touch with Toby? Oh, she is? I see. No, thanks, let it go, forget it. *(Hangs up.)* The wife of Rabbi Kaplan! I'm cursed. I cannot get a break. *(Thumbs book.)* Marilyn Perry. The queen of Dubrow's. *(Dials.)* Hello, is this the Perry residence? Ah, is Marilyn there? *(Rises and crosses R.)* You know where I can reach her? An old friend from Midwood High School—Allan Felix. I dated her once. Do you remember? I'm stunned! It was eleven years ago . . . that's right . . . short, with red hair and glasses—no, that's cleared up. How can I get in touch with her? Oh, really? She still feels that way? You know it's been eleven years now. When did you speak to her? Last week . . . and she specified she didn't want you to give me the number? Well, goodbye, Mrs. Perry. No, that's all right. *(Hangs up and puts phone on bench.)* I don't know how much longer I can take this. I miss being married. These past two weeks have been terrible. At least Linda's been fixing me up with some of her friends. But with every girl something goes wrong. First there was that photographer's assistant, Sharon. I made a mess of that. Then the next night there was Gina.

(GINA enters—U. R. C. slot—as LIGHTS CHANGE and

ALLAN falls into step with her as they cross to the downstage railing.)

GINA. Good night, Allan. *(He moves to embrace her.)*
Don't!

ALLAN. Why not?

GINA. I'm Catholic.

ALLAN. I'll convert.

GINA. Besides, I didn't take my pill today. *(Exits bedroom door, slamming it behind her.)*

ALLAN. That's all right. . . . I took an extra one! *(LIGHTS RESTORE.)* What'd I do wrong? She treated me cold from the second I showed up at her door with a Whitman Sampler. And what about Vanessa? That was only a week ago . . . you'd think by then my luck would have begun to change.

(LIGHTS DIM to a late-night romantic mood. VANESSA, exotically dressed, appears—from U. L. slot—and glides to the sofa where she reclines. Soft MUSIC in the background. ALLAN joins her.)

VANESSA. I've had many men . . . my first at twelve. After that it was an endless stream. Poets, writers. I lived in a house with five actors. Some were gay, but what does it matter? I straightened them out. It was a challenge. My life was a continual round of orgies. I took on the entire Tau Epsilon Phi Fraternity at Yale in three hours. It's still a record in New Haven. I've always thought of sex as something wonderful and open . . . to be enjoyed as fully and frequently as possible. *(ALLAN, increasingly aroused, finally can restrain himself no longer and lunges for her. She screams and jumps up.)* Aaaaagh! What do you take me for? *(She exits U. L. slot as LIGHTS RESTORE.)*

ALLAN. How did I misread those signs? . . . What am I going to do? I've practically used up every friend Linda has. I may have to resort to desperate measures to meet

women . . . like going up to Eas hampton or hanging around Bloomingdale's stocking counter. Ah . . . I'm too shy to do those things alone. Linda would come with me even if Dick's busy. Dick and Linda sure have been great. I've dragged them everywhere to help me find girls. Linda seems to like it. I know she enjoyed that evening at the discotheque. *(Sits corner of bench.)*

club special on sound on
(LIGHTS DIM. DICK and LINDA join ALLAN from the D. R. slot and sit at the corner of the bench. On the platform behind them a fantastic little BLONDE in a glittering dress is bumping and jerking to drive you crazy. MUSIC blares.)

LINDA. Gee, this is fun. We haven't been to a discotheque in such a long time. *club*

ALLAN. I'm getting a heart attack. I can't believe that girl.

DICK. *(Into phone.)* I'm at Lehigh 4-3605.

ALLAN. She's a doll! I would sell my mother to the Arabs for that girl!

LINDA. Well, ask her to dance. You've been staring at her for an hour.

ALLAN. I can't . . . I don't know her.

DICK. *(Puts phone down, and turns to them.)* Come on. I can't stay any longer. I have to get up early tomorrow and sue some friends.

LINDA. You want to dance one dance, honey?

DICK. We can't do those dances. They're undignified. You've got to be under sixteen to look good. But you two can stay, just don't get home too late. Good luck. *(Exits thru kitchen.)*

ALLAN. I love you, Miss—whoever you are—I want to have your child.

(MUSIC segues to a relatively slow number.)

LINDA. Get up and do it.

ALLAN. I can't dance—have you ever seen my body move? It's like a printing press.

LINDA. (*Dragging him to the platform.*) Come on. . . .

ALLAN. I'm scared—please—no—no. . . .

LINDA. Start dancing . . . that's it . . . keep count . . . one . . . two . . . one . . . two. Now talk to her. Go ahead.

ALLAN. One . . . two . . . one . . . two . . .

LINDA. Try something more meaningful.

ALLAN. Three . . . four . . . three . . . four. . . .

LINDA. NO! . . . Go on. . . .

ALLAN. Er . . . good evening, miss. Would you be interested in dancing?

GIRL. Sure!

(*MUSIC SWITCHES abruptly to wild rock as the GIRL thrashes appropriately. In a desperate effort to look good ALLAN attempts a few vaguely Spanish fandangos. LINDA has slipped off D. R. at the start of this. The GIRL dances her way U. C., sees ALLAN and erupts into derisive laughter, backing off U. R. C. slot. LIGHTS RESTORE and MUSIC FADES.*)

ALLAN. What I need is a more intellectual girl . . . that's where my appeal is . . . that's why last Monday afternoon the Museum of Modern Art seemed such a good idea. . . .

VP
(*LIGHTS FADE leaving an aisle of light across the fore-stage. LINDA enters D. R. slot wearing a raincoat. ALLAN joins her.*)

LINDA. Um . . . look at that Salvador Dali . . . if you could have any painting in the world, what would you pick? (*Thru these speeches they drift L.*)

ALLAN. A Van Gogh. Any Van Gogh.

LINDA. Me too. I feel some kind of mystical attraction for Van Gogh. Why is that?

ALLAN. All I know is that he's a great, great painter and he cut his ear off for a girl he loved.

LINDA. That's the kind of thing you'd do for a girl.

ALLAN. Yeah. . . . (*Embarrassed.*) I'd really have to like her a lot.

LINDA. I wonder if Dick would cut his ear off for me.

ALLAN. I don't think you better ask him. He's been very busy, lately.

LINDA. It must be fantastic to be loved so intensely.

ALLAN. I guess we may as well split and see if there's any action at the Guggenheim.

(*A pretty BLONDE wearing low-cut jeans and shirt tied high, exposing a lovely midriff, wearing moccasins and a shoulder bag, enters from D. L. slot.*)

LINDA. Here comes one.

ALLAN. Ah . . . she is one.

LINDA. Go ahead . . . speak to her.

ALLAN. I'll get arrested.

LINDA. Go ahead before the room gets crowded and you feel ashamed.

ALLAN. (*To GIRL.*) Uh . . . that's quite a lovely Franz Kline, isn't it?

GIRL. Yes, it is.

ALLAN. What does it say to you? (*LINDA sits swivel—turns upstage.*)

GIRL. It restates the negativeness of the universe. The hideous, lonely emptiness of existence—nothingness—the predicament of man, forced to live in a barren, godless eternity, like a tiny flame flickering in an immense void—with nothing but waste, horror, and degradation—forming a useless, bleak straitjacket in a black absurd cosmos.

ALLAN. What are you doing Saturday night?

GIRL. (*Exiting.*) Committing suicide.

ALLAN. What about Friday night? Intellectual women are a pain in the neck—got to be the right mixture of brains and passion. Now Linda's got it all. She's so easy

lights
restage

to be with . . . like that day last week in Central Park . . . she was sweet, and friendly, and tried her best to be helpful. (*Moves to the hassock c. and sits, starts to mime rowing a boat . . . appropriate SOUNDS are heard.* *Linda has been sitting in the swivel chair and spins around to face front.*)

LINDA. Don't you understand, Allan? You have a lot going for you. You're bright and funny and even romantic, if you could only believe it. You put on a false mask as soon as you meet a girl.

ALLAN. It's different around you. You're my friend's wife. I'm not trying to impress you.

LINDA. I keep telling you . . . be yourself. The girl will fall in love with you.

ALLAN. Listen, you've been so nice this past week, spending your time with me. (*Stops rowing and pulls a small tissue-wrapped object from his pocket.*)

LINDA. I'll tell you the truth, I'm having a ball.

ALLAN. (*Takes present from pocket.*) I wanted to get you this because it's your birthday.

LINDA. How did you know it was my birthday?

ALLAN. You mentioned it one day and I remembered it because it's the same date my mother had her hysterectomy.

LINDA. (*Moving to kneel on the hassock just behind him.*) It's lovely—it's beautiful—a tiny plastic skunk.

ALLAN. It looked so cute in F. A. O. Schwartz and I heard you say skunks are your favorite animals . . . it doesn't function . . . it just exists. . . .

LINDA. I'm so touched. I don't know what to say. (*Sits back in swivel and swings around to face upstage and exits R. C. Hot. Allan goes back to rowing, then as the LIGHTS CHANGE finds himself back in his living room.*)

ALLAN. Linda's a great girl. I think Dick kind of neglects her. Hell, I told him so the other night. If I'm his friend, I've got to speak candidly to him. He's gotta learn to take it easy and treat her a little better.

ACT II *PLAY IT AGAIN, SAM*
(The *LIGHTS CHANGE* and DICK enters from R. C. slot.)

DICK. (Crosses to sofa, puts brief case on coffee table.)
How could you get her a birthday present and I forget?
Why didn't you warn me?

ALLAN. She's your wife. I assumed you knew.

DICK. (Crosses to phone on bench.) I'm up to my ears
in work. I purchased fifty lots for building in Tennessee,
it turns out they're radioactive. I'm taking a beating.
(Dials.)

ALLAN. Maybe if you just took Linda out once in a
while.

DICK. That's the farthest thing from my mind. Besides,
I went to a discotheque with both of you last week.

ALLAN. That was one night, two weeks ago, and you
left early, and you wouldn't dance with her, and you for-
got her birthday.

DICK. I didn't forget completely. I was late. My sec-
retary picked her up some jewelry.

ALLAN. Your secretary? That's not very personal.
Women like personal junk. . . .

DICK. You know what it is to be stuck with fifty lots
that are radioactive? What am I going to build, an X-ray
center? (To the phone.) Hello, Miss Carson? What are
the figures on the new contract, fifteen hundred or eight-
teen hundred? . . . Thank you. (Hangs up and crosses
back to sofa.)

ALLAN. So once in a while you take her dancing or on
a picnic.

DICK. Maybe, who knows . . . maybe I got married
too young. She was so beautiful . . . first in her class at
Bard College. I'll never forget that prom weekend, there
was moonlight, and soft music, I looked at her with her
hair spilling down her shoulders and thought—she's the
perfect corporate image for a young executive.

ALLAN. I hate to tell you, pal, but that sounds a little
callous.

DICK. Oh, come on, Allan, she knows I love her. Christ, I'm crazy about her, and have been since the second I met her. Meanwhile, between my quicksand and my radioactivity, I'll be driving a cab soon. (*The LIGHTS CHANGE and DICK vanishes.*)

ALLAN. Some guys don't know a good thing when they have one. (*Rises from hassock and crosses to desk.*) Well, I gotta stop daydreaming. . . . I'm going to lose my job if I don't finish my essay on Anna May Wong. (*Door BUZZES. He answers it and it is LINDA.*) Hi.

LINDA. Hi.

ALLAN. What's the matter?

LINDA. I hope I'm not bothering you . . . what do you have for an anxiety attack? I need a tranquilizer.

ALLAN. I got everything. I'm a drugstore.

LINDA. I have a throbbing in the pit of my stomach.

ALLAN. How do you know it's anxiety?—How do you know it's not fear?

LINDA. My stomach feels jumpy.

ALLAN. You find it hard to breathe?

LINDA. A little—I feel frightened, and I don't know over what.

ALLAN. I get that.

LINDA. Is it fear or anxiety?

ALLAN. Homosexual panic. (*Exits to bedroom.*)

LINDA. Oh . . . I always get this way when Dick goes on a business trip.

ALLAN. (*Off.*) Oh?

LINDA. He had to fly to Cleveland for the day. I got up, helped him pack, drove him to the airport, and threw up in the United Airlines terminal.

ALLAN. (*Returning with pill and water.*) That's a good terminal. I've thrown up there.

LINDA. I don't know what it is that upsets me so.

ALLAN. Fear of separation. It's an interesting psychological phenomenon. I had to go to Washington once when I was married, and even though I was the one leaving, I

got sick. Yet when I returned, my wife threw up. (*Returns glass to bedroom.*)

LINDA. My analyst would say I'm feeling guilty because I really want him to go.

ALLAN. (*Reenters from bedroom.*) Come on. . . . I don't understand you . . . you got everything going for you. You're bright . . . people photograph you for magazines, so you know you're beautiful. You read, you play Bach on the ⁽¹¹⁸¹³⁵⁾recliner, you're happily married. I mean, why should you be a mass of symptoms?

LINDA. Well, you've got a lot going for you, and you're a mass of symptoms. I guess it happens to us when we're children . . . you know, you think you're ugly and your parents get divorced . . . you feel abandoned . . . you must have had the same thing.

ALLAN. My parents didn't get divorced . . . although I begged them to.

LINDA. (*Sits sofa.*) Do you really think I've got a lot going for me?

ALLAN. I do. And I'm fussy. I don't know how I can afford to be, but I am.

LINDA. It's funny. I never thought you liked me very much. You know, when I married Dick.

ALLAN. I thought you didn't like me so much. I thought maybe you thought I was an oddball.

LINDA. I never really knew you. I mean we never spent any time together. Dick described you as the first guy who sat through "The Maltese Falcon" twelve times in two weeks. Then when the four of us went out together you acted differently than now. I feel I've really gotten to know you in the past few weeks and I've come to a very interesting conclusion. You definitely are an oddball . . . but you're one of the best people I've ever known.

ALLAN. That's nice. Because you're the only really Platonic friend I've ever had.

LINDA. I like a Platonic relationship. They're so much less complicated. Not that I'm down on male-female

relationships—although marriage is a tough proposition at best.

ALLAN. It's disastrous.

LINDA. I know. Dick and I are constantly, quote, re-appraising our marriage.

ALLAN. Are you?

Stand
SR
LINDA. Sure. Especially in the last year. You know he's gotten deeper and deeper into his work and my interests have gone in another area. That is, they always were. There are certain things we both need that we don't give each other.

ALLAN. Marriage can be a very lonely thing. But not so lonely as I've been since I've been single.

LINDA. Hey, no date tonight?

ALLAN. Ah . . . I had a date but she called it off . . . some kind of Polish holiday.

LINDA. Well, why don't we go out to dinner and maybe a movie?

ALLAN. I got a better idea. Why don't we have dinner here and see what's on the Late Show?

LINDA. You have anything here for me to cook?

ALLAN. I have some frozen steaks and a bottle of champagne.

LINDA. What are you doing with champagne? You going to launch a ship?

ALLAN. I tried cooking here last week—to impress a date. I tried to make Beef Stroganoff in the pressure cooker.

LINDA. How'd it taste?

ALLAN. I don't know. It's still on the wall.

LINDA. Is the grocery on the corner still open?

ALLAN. Yes.

LINDA. (*Rises, gets purse off coffee table.*) I'll be right back. I'll get us some asparagus and salad and dessert. I love to cook and I never get the chance—Dick's so busy all the time.

ALLAN. And get some candles. I love to eat by candlelight.

LINDA. I'll cook and you open the champagne. But not if I'm going to be the only one who drinks it.

ALLAN. I'll drink one or two with you but you've got to promise to put me to bed if I try and dance naked.

(LINDA exits.) Hey, this'll be fun! I have a terrific rapport with Linda. I hate to see her depressed. It'll be cozy.

(Puts pillows from couch by fireplace.) Spending an evening in . . . nice summer ~~rain~~ outside . . . (Closes shutters.) It's just damp enough to have a small fire. Adjust the lighting in here. (Turns on light on bar.) Create a little atmosphere. (Picks up address book from coffee table, puts on desk shelf, starts for kitchen.) Get out the champagne. Women are suckers for champagne . . . it makes them crazy. (Out from kitchen.) Wait a minute . . . what the hell am I doing! Women are suckers for champagne. This is Linda. Dick's wife. Linda. Remember? Gee, I got carried away for a minute. What the hell was I thinking?

LINDA. (Enters U. L. slot. Soft MUSIC under. They meet on sofa.) Dinner was wonderful, Allan. The steaks were superb, the champagne perfect. I'm so glad we decided to stay home and spend a quiet evening together. You're the only man I've ever met who really holds my interest.

ALLAN. You should feel flattered. Not many women are deep enough to know what it is I'm all about.

LINDA. (Kissing him.) I'm sorry for acting like a schoolgirl—I couldn't help myself. I've wanted to do that for so long now.

ALLAN. We mustn't. It's forbidden.

LINDA. But these things happen. Nobody plans them.

ALLAN. Yes, but you're not free.

LINDA. In my heart I'm free. I can't repress it any longer. At first I thought you were just a helpless, mixed-up child, but I didn't really know you then. Now I believe you're everything I ever dreamed of loving.

ALLAN. You poor thing. How you must've suffered—wanting me so.

LINDA. My darling, I need you. I need to possess you body and soul.

ALLAN. Which would you like to begin with?

LINDA. (*Rises, crosses to mantel.*) We were meant for each other. If we miss this opportunity we'll regret it as long as we live.

ALLAN. My head says it's insane, but my heart says, don't believe your head, it's a lying head. (*LINDA vanishes U. L. slot.*) This is terrible. I'm ~~sitting~~ ^{standing} here making love to my best friend's pillow.

BOGART. (*Enters U. R. C. slot.*) So, you finally fell in love with her.

ALLAN. I just got carried away for a minute.

BOGART. Come on, kid, you don't have to feel guilty.

ALLAN. Guilty over what? Two lonely people with a tremendous amount in common have dinner together. We're Platonic friends.

BOGART. There's nothing Platonic about the way she feels about you.

ALLAN. How can you tell?

BOGART. What do you want her to do—attack you?

ALLAN. She's my friend's wife.

NANCY. (*Enters U. L. slot.*) Of course she is. She'll tell Dick and he'll beat you to a pulp.

BOGART. Look, she loves you, not him.

NANCY. He's not the romantic type.

BOGART. He could be if he tried.

NANCY. Don't listen to him.

BOGART. Don't listen to her.

ALLAN. I'm getting a headache.

(NANCY and BOGART exit.)

DICK. (*Enters D. R.*) Allan, I want you to do me a favor.

ALLAN. Yes?

DICK. I've fallen in love with another woman. Don't ask me how—it just happened. We're going off together

to live in Alaska. Oh, she's an Eskimo. I know that you and Linda have always been fond of one another and I thought perhaps after I'm gone you might look after her. It would mean a lot to me.

ALLAN. Of course.

DICK. Well, I'm off to Alaska. If you need me I'll be at Frozen Tundra 7-0659. (*Vanishes D. R. slot.*)

ALLAN. She is always complimenting me. I know she likes me. But does she like me that way? What the hell? I could test her. I could maybe make an advance . . . what could possibly go wrong?

(*DREAM LIGHT*). LINDA appears from U. L. slot and crosses to sofa. *MUSIC UNDER.*)

LINDA. Dinner was wonderful, Allan. The steaks were superb, the champagne perfect. (*Sits on sofa.*)

ALLAN. (*Crosses to sit on sofa.*) Linda, tonight the earth shook.

LINDA. What?

ALLAN. Linda darling . . .

LINDA. Don't . . .

ALLAN. It was meant to be . . .

LINDA. Allan, take your hands off me, you must be crazy.

ALLAN. Linda, my love . . .

LINDA. Allan, I'm a married woman. Rape!

ALLAN. Shhh . . . you'll wake up the whole house!

LINDA. Think of Dick—he's your best friend. (*They rise.*)

ALLAN. My sleeve is caught on your zipper!

LINDA. Thank God, Dick gave me this tear gas pen! (*Mimes pen business as a loud JET SPRAY SOUND is heard, and exits U. L. slot.* ALLAN covers his face coughing as *LIGHTS RESTORE.*)

ALLAN. (*Pacing R. and L.*) Look, let's not get carried away. I'm not an appealing guy. The thought that a girl like Linda could go for me . . . I'm kidding myself. Where the hell is she? By now she could have had her

Level
4

back
to

steak and been home! (*Door BUZZES. ALLAN opens it. LINDA enters for real with bag of groceries.*)

LINDA. I feel so light. That Librium is beginning to work.

ALLAN. (*Takes bag.*) Maybe you better not have any champagne.

LINDA. (*Takes candles from bag.*) Oh, no, what the hell—if I get too out of hand you can always call the police.

ALLAN. (*Into kitchen with bag.*) How long did you say Dick was out of town for?

LINDA. He'll be back tomorrow.

ALLAN. (*Enters from kitchen.*) There's a new Godard film at the Sutton . . . I thought maybe we could go—

LINDA. (*Gets candlesticks from shelf above bar.*) Come on—you're kidding . . . we're all set for here. . . . Besides, it's starting to rain. Besides, I remembered that great Ida Lupino movie is on Channel Four . . . you know, where she's married and she suddenly becomes involved with her husband's best friend.

ALLAN. How does it end?

LINDA. (*Sits on sofa, puts candles in sticks.*) She kills them and herself.

ALLAN. (*Crosses down to sofa R.*) Let's go out.

LINDA. (*Puts candles on mantel, turns on sconce switch, then picks up pillows near fireplace.*) I want to see that Ida Lupino movie. It's a fascinating theme. You think it's possible to love two people at once?

ALLAN. (*To C. sofa.*) What do you mean?

LINDA. (*Crosses in to ALLAN at sofa, puts one pillow on sofa.*) A wife, happily married, suddenly finds she loves another man . . . not that she doesn't love her husband . . . just that . . . she loves someone else . . . you think it's very possible?

ALLAN. Do you?

LINDA. Very. Very possible and probably very common. Love is such a strange phenomenon . . . strange and exquisite. . . .

ACT II

PLAY IT AGAIN, SAM

41

Spot Fix cut to page 37
BOGART. (*Appears L. c. slot.*) Go ahead. Make your move.

ALLAN. Uh—

BOGART. (*Crosses in to ALLAN on sofa R.*) Go ahead. Take her and kiss her.

ALLAN. Uh— (*Paralyzed to act on this advice.*) Uh—

LINDA. Is something wrong?

BOGART. Go ahead. She wants it.

ALLAN. Wrong? No—I—

LINDA. I better begin our food.

BOGART. Go ahead. Kiss her.

Linda. Yes?

BOGART. ~~Hurry!~~ Before she moves out of position.

ALLAN. I—can't do it.

BOGART. Kiss her, kid!

ALLAN. I—I—can't!

LINDA. I'll be right back. (*Turns and goes off to kitchen, puts other pillow on sofa.*) ~~Onstage~~

BOGART. (*Sits swivel.*) Well, kid! You blew it.

ALLAN. I can't do it. She'll misunderstand it. I invite her over and I come on like a sex degenerate! How does it look? What am I, a rapist?

BOGART. You're getting carried away. You think too much. Just do it.

ALLAN. We're Platonic friends. I can't spoil that by suddenly coming on. She'll slap my face.

BOGART. I've had my face slapped plenty of times.

ALLAN. Yeah, but your glasses don't go flying across the room.

BOGART. (*Rises, crosses up above R. corner of sofa.*) You're going to disappoint her.

LINDA. (*Enters with two glasses of champagne.*) Here we are. Start on this. (*Hands him glass, crosses below coffee table to L. corner of sofa.*) Hey, did you read in the papers, another Queens woman was raped?

ALLAN. (*Practically spits up his first swallow.*) Oh, really? I was nowhere near Queens! Do they know who did it?

LINDA. (*Sits on sofa, L. end.*) No. They haven't a clue. He must be very clever.

ALLAN. (*Sits R. end of sofa.*) You've got to have something on the ball to rape so many women and get away with it. Ah-ha . . . (*He's trying to be light. He looks at BOGART who doesn't smile.*)

LINDA. I think if anyone ever tried to rape me I'd pretend to go along with it and then right in the middle pick up the nearest heavy object and let him have it. (*BOGART and ALLAN look troubled.*) Unless, of course, I was enjoying it. (*BOTH MEN brighten.*)

ALLAN. They say it's the secret desire of every woman.

LINDA. Well, I guess it depends on who does the raping.

ALLAN. Well look, why dwell on morbid things? Odds are you'll never get raped.

LINDA. Not with my luck. (*Closes her eyes happily.*) Um—I feel so light. The drink went right to my head. I'm floating.

ALLAN. Um. (*Agreeing.*)

BOGART. Go ahead, kiss her.

ALLAN. I can't.

BOGART. She's ready.

ALLAN. How do you know?

BOGART. Believe me. I know.

ALLAN. She'll pull back. I feel it.

BOGART. She's sitting and waiting. Don't screw up.

ALLAN. O.K.—I'm going to try. . . . But I'm gonna go slow . . . (*Begins inching into position. Very scared.*) If she jumps I'll pretend it was a joke.

BOGART. Hurry.

ALLAN. She better laugh. (*Just as he's about to strike, the PHONE RINGS with shattering clarity and he jumps with a near heart attack.*) Ohmigod! Didn't expect that! (*He goes to pick up phone.*) What a start. . . . (*Into phone.*) Hello? Dick? Hi . . . What? Yes . . . she is. She dropped over—very unexpectedly. I had a Polish date.—Two good friends—we're going to have one fast dinner, then right out.—Huh? Yes, I'm all right. I'm fine. Say,

aren't you in Cleveland? Oh, then this call is costing you money. . . . I'll put her on. . . . (*Offers her phone.*) He wants to speak to you. From Cleveland. (*BOGART crosses above sofa.*)

LINDA. (*To ALLAN, en route to phone.*) Are you upset over anything?

ALLAN. Oh no . . . I was just startled. . . . (*LINDA sits on bench, speaks into phone. ALLAN crosses L. to L. end of sofa.*) This is ridiculous. I'm going to cause an international incident. I want her out. I can't handle this.

LINDA. Hello, darling.

ALLAN. Hello, darling. She loves him. Why am I kidding myself?

BOGART. (*Crosses down to L. corner of sofa.*) Will you relax. You're as nervous as Elizabeth Scott was before I blew her brains out. All you gotta do is make your move and you're home free.

ALLAN. This is crazy. We'll all wind up on the front page of the *National Enquirer*.

LINDA. Okay. Goodbye. I will. (*Hangs up.*) Dick sounded a little down. I think he's having some trouble in Cleveland.

ALLAN. How come he never takes you with him when he goes on those out-of-town trips?

LINDA. (*Crosses to sofa, sits R.*) I'm afraid to fly. My analyst thinks that's an excuse. He never asks me along, though. Who knows? Maybe he's got something going on the side. (*This last said jokingly.*)

ALLAN. (*Sits on sofa L. of LINDA.*) Would that bother you?

LINDA. Sure. I mean not if I didn't know.

ALLAN. I know he'd be very hurt if you ever had a casual affair with somebody else.

LINDA. I don't think I could have a casual affair.

ALLAN. No?

LINDA. I don't take those things lightly. If I fell for another man there'd have to be something more there than a little fling. I'd have to feel something more serious, in

which case my marriage would be in question. Are you shaking?

ALLAN. I'm chilly.

LINDA. It's not very cold. I'm not the type, though. I don't think I could take the excitement involved. Anyway, I'm not glamorous enough.

ALLAN. Oh, you are. You're uncommonly beautiful.

LINDA. When I go to a discotheque and see all those beautiful young girls I feel like life has passed me by. I should be selling chocolates at Fanny Farmer.

ALLAN. You're crazy! Those girls are not in your league.

LINDA. Keep talking. You're saving my life. I have such an inferiority complex.

BOGART. Say, you're handling yourself very well. Now kiss her.

ALLAN. Please—

BOGART. You built up to it beautifully.

ALLAN. I just don't have the nerve.

BOGART. Tell her how beautiful she is again.

ALLAN. I just told her!

BOGART. Again.

ALLAN. Y'know, you are really one of the most beautiful girls I've ever known.

LINDA. I don't know what to say to that.

ALLAN. I mean really beautiful—unbelievably beautiful—fantastically beautiful—

BOGART. All right already.

LINDA. It's been so long since anybody said that to me.

BOGART. Now move closer to her.

ALLAN. How close?

BOGART. The length of your lips.

ALLAN. That's very close.

BOGART. Come on. Move. (ALLAN does.)

ALLAN. Now what?

BOGART. Tell her that she moves something in you that you can't control.

ALLAN. You're kidding.

look at
white

drink

BOGART. Go ahead.

ALLAN. From me it's corny.

BOGART. She'll love it.

ALLAN. It's like Fred Astaire looks great in tails, I look silly.

BOGART. Leave Fred Astaire out of this. Say something.

ALLAN. I love the time we've spent together.

LINDA. So have I.

ALLAN. Was that all right?—I don't want to use your other line about moving something in me.

BOGART. You're doing fine, kid. Tell her she has the most irresistible eyes you've ever seen.

ALLAN. Eyes you,—you eyes—you—you have the *most* eyes of anybody . . .

LINDA. Your hand is trembling.

ALLAN. It is?

BOGART. That's because you're near.

ALLAN. Pardon me?

BOGART. Tell her that!

ALLAN. That's because you're near.

LINDA. You always know what to say, don't you?

BOGART. Tell her you've met a lot of dames but she's really something special.

ALLAN. That she won't believe.

BOGART. No?

ALLAN. I've met a lot of dames but you are really something special.

LINDA. Really?

ALLAN. She bought it.

BOGART. Now put your right hand around her shoulder and draw her near.

ALLAN. I don't want to—I'm afraid.

BOGART. Go ahead. (ALLAN *does it*.) Now get ready for the big move and do exactly as I tell you.

(NANCY enters from U. R. C. slot with gun.)

NANCY. I warned you to leave my ex-husband alone.

play it

*Dream
light*

(She shoots BOGART. NANCY exits U. R. C. slot, BOGART exits U. L. slot.) *lights out*

LINDA. Well, I guess I'll start the steaks.

ALLAN. Linda, your eyes are like two thick steaks. (*Has summoned his courage and tries to kiss her. She bangs backwards, knocking over the standing lamp on the sofa table.*)

LINDA. Allan, don't! I'll pay for the lamp.

ALLAN. It's all right! I think I love you!

LINDA. I insist on paying for the lamp!

ALLAN. (*Still in a wrestle.*) Forget the lamp!

LINDA. I'm so clumsy—will you take ten dollars!

ALLAN. (*Still going for her bobbing head.*) Forget the damn lamp! Give me five bucks, we'll call it square!

LINDA. (*Disengaged, she rises and gets purse from bench.*) Allan—don't—

ALLAN. Don't get the wrong idea—it was a joke—I was testing you—you don't think—I meant a Platonic kiss—not a whole kiss—here—

LINDA. I better go.

ALLAN. (*Following.*) Linda . . .

LINDA. I really better go.

ALLAN. Linda.

LINDA. Please. I'll be fine. (*Awkwardly, she goes.*)

ALLAN. (*Alone, frantic.*) I attacked her! What did I do? I'm a vicious jungle beast! She's going to tell Dick! She's panicky now! By the time she gets home she'll be hysterical! She'll probably go right to Police Headquarters! What kind of idiot am I to try a fool thing like that! I'm not Bogart. I never will be Bogart. What'll I tell Dick? I'm a disgrace to my sex. I should work in an Arabian palace as a eunuch. (*BUZZ.*) There's the Vice Squad. (*Turns. Opens door. LINDA enters.*)

LINDA. Did you say you loved me? (*They kiss.*)

ALLAN. Play it again, Sam! (*MUSIC up.*)

W. A. F. Co.
CURTAIN

lights up

ACT THREE

CURTAIN rises on ALLAN and LINDA, the following morning, after they have "done it." It has been a mixed thing for them; beautiful and traumatic. They are on the sofa with coffee mugs.

ALLAN. Two lonely people with a tremendous amount in common thrown together continually—before we know what's happening, we're in love . . . we fight it as long as possible, we're alone on a rainy summer evening, Dick's a thousand miles away, we couldn't fight it any longer, I took you in my arms and we made love. Then we each got upset stomachs. The main thing is that we're honest.

LINDA. I still can't believe it.

ALLAN. I haven't slept that well in years. Is it noon yet?

LINDA. It's seven.

ALLAN. Seven? I didn't realize it was so early. You were fantastic last night.

LINDA. Thanks.

ALLAN. How do you feel now?

LINDA. I think the Pepto-Bismol helped. What were you thinking of while we were doing it?

ALLAN. Willie Mays.

LINDA. You always think of baseball players when you're making love?

ALLAN. It keeps me going.

LINDA. I couldn't figure out why you kept yelling, slide.

ALLAN. I think it'd probably be best if you told Dick.

LINDA. Dick?

ALLAN. I guess it'll come as a surprise, but . . .

LINDA. Oh . . . it'll be a surprise all right. . . .

ALLAN. Make sure you tell him on a day that Wall Street closes high.

LINDA. Gee . . . the whole thing is complicated.

ALLAN. Listen, it happened, it happened—can't help that. It happened. It's not my fault. It's not your fault. The point is—you felt like a woman, and I felt like a man, and that's what those kind of people do.

LINDA. I did feel like a woman. You were wonderful.

ALLAN. I have a fantastic craving for breakfast.

LINDA. I'll make some. What are you in the mood for?

ALLAN. Steak and eggs, pancakes, butter and syrup, biscuits, and a big pot of coffee.

LINDA. (*Rising.*) Well! In that case, I'd better go downstairs and pick up a few things.

ALLAN. Don't bother . . . we'll go out.

LINDA. (*Gets purse from bench.*) No . . . no . . . I'll go. I need a little fresh air.

ALLAN. Take my raincoat, there's money in the pocket.

LINDA. Wait'll my analyst comes back from his vacation and finds out about this. He'll become a chiropodist. (*Exits.*)

ALLAN. You killer! You were incredible in bed last night . . . like Toscanini. Nancy should have been there—she'd have seen a master in action.

NANCY. (*Appears in DREAM LIGHT.*) Oh, Allan, word's out all over Europe that you're the best thing in bed the United States has to offer.

Frosty
over
ALLAN. You could have had some of this and you threw it away.

NANCY. I made a mistake. I know that now. Can't we start over?

ALLAN. It's too late. Linda and I are in love. We're going away.

NANCY. I've been a fool. (*ORGAN MUSIC.*) Good-bye, Allan, I'm going to become a nun. If I can't have you, the next best thing is God. (*Vanishes D. R. slot.*)

What
ALLAN. She's got a point there. Gee, I can't believe it. This bright beautiful woman is in love with me. Of course

she's in love with me. Why shouldn't she be? I'm bright, amusing . . . sensitive face . . . fantastic body. Dick'll understand. Hell, we're two civilized guys. In the course of our social encounters a little romance has developed. It's a very natural thing to happen amongst sophisticated people.

DICK. (*Appearing in DREAM LIGHT R. C. slot.*) You sent for me? Enter R

ALLAN. Yes.

DICK. Good.

ALLAN. Drink?

DICK. Quite.

ALLAN. Scotch?

DICK. Fine.

ALLAN. Neat?

DICK. Please.

ALLAN. Soda?

DICK. A dash.

ALLAN. Linda and I are in love.

DICK. It's just as well. I've come from my doctor. He gives me two months to live.

ALLAN. Good, then you don't mind?

DICK. Not a bit.

ALLAN. Cheers.

DICK. Cheers. (*Vanishes R. C. slot.*) out R

ALLAN. (*Rises, crosses in to C.*) Sure . . . things are going to be okay. Hell, Dick and I have been through tougher situations than this. Dick and I have been through a lot together. He's my best friend. This is terrible. This is going to hurt him . . . I know it. in UL

DICK. (*Enters D. R. slot, DREAM LIGHT.*) Thanks a lot.

ALLAN. Dick . . .

DICK. (*Crosses L. of sofa.*) How could you? My wife and my best friend. I trusted you both. I feel I've been made such a fool of. I loved her. I loved you. Why didn't I see it coming? Me—who had the foresight to buy Polaroid at eight and a half! (*Disappears U. L. slot.*)

ALLAN. This is awful . . . he'll do something rash. Dick's an emotional guy. He'll kill himself. Kill himself? Did you ever think what he might do to you? Didn't you ever hear of the unwritten law? You take a guy's wife . . . you humiliate him. You've seen enough Italian movies. Dick's got a temper!

OL / DICK. (*Enters in undershirt and scarf.*) Bastardo! Pezzo di curnutu. Tu mai tradutto me!

ALLAN. (*Backing up R. steps onto platform.*) Ma non e vero.

DICK. Tu mi pigli per stupido!

ALLAN. Non e curpa mia.

DICK. (*Leaps railing.*) Bugiardo! proco! Carogna! Imbesile! (*Draws dagger.*)

ALLAN. No . . . no . . .

DICK. Solo chisto me tuo sadisfari mio onore. (*Stabs ALLAN.*)

ALLAN. Oh boy, that hurt! (*DICK exits U. R. C. slot.* ALLAN, *at railing.*) This is ridiculous! What am I going to do? I love her. She loves me. We could have a wonderful life together. Why does Dick have to be in the picture? Hell, take it easy. Why do you have to make everything into a Warner Brothers production? She'll come back, we'll have breakfast together. Shape up. She'll be back in a minute. You'll spend the day together. . . . (*DOOR BUZZ. ALLAN opens it to find DICK with suitcase and coat.*)

DICK. (*Coat and case at railing, crosses D. L.*) I had to come home, Allan. I have to speak to you. Allan, I think Linda's having an affair. I just called home. She's not there. These past few weeks she's seemed distracted, distant, little things only a husband would notice. You've seen her a lot these past couple of weeks . . . she's changed. The other night she talked about an affair in her sleep.

ALLAN. Did she mention any names?

DICK. Only yours. When I woke her and questioned her she said it was just a nightmare. (*Crosses R. up steps onto*

platform.) I try to think of who it might be. It has to be someone I don't know . . . some guy she met through work . . . an agent, a photographer, some ad executive, or actor.

ALLAN. Why are you so upset . . . I thought she was just your corporate image?

DICK. I love her. If she leaves me I'll kill myself.

ALLAN. Since when are you so emotional?

DICK. I've never been in love with anyone before. If I find out who the guy is I'll kill him, I swear. I've neglected her and now she's involved with some stud! *(ALLAN sits swivel hassock, DICK sits edge of coffee table.)* If I haven't already lost her to someone I'm going to make up for everything to her. I'm going to change. I'm going to do everything I can to make her life with me exciting and fun because without her it wouldn't be worth living. I was up all last night in a Cleveland hotel room. I figured all right, I'm losing her . . . too bad . . . I'll survive. Then I panicked and phoned her. She was out. When I called her here last night she said she was going home. Where'd she stay?

ALLAN. *(Rising.)* Calm yourself.

DICK. *(Rises, crosses R., then back to ALLAN.)* I've got to find her. I've got to stop her and beg her forgiveness before it's too late. I want her to get on that plane with me and fly back to Cleveland. I want her with me all the time. I want to pamper her. I want to hear her laugh and speak. . . . I'm sorry for carrying on like this, Allan, but you're the only friend in the world who would understand.

ALLAN. I . . . I understand.

DICK. Look, if she calls, tell her I'll see her at home. Tell her I've got to speak to her, will you?

ALLAN. Sure . . . sure.

DICK. Thanks . . . thanks a lot. *(Gets coat and suitcase and exits.)*

ALLAN. *(Sits coffee table.)* I'm going to faint. How could I tell him? The guy's desperately in love with her.

I never realized how much. He never realized how much. I couldn't do that to a stranger, much less a friend. But what if it's too late? What if Linda's really hooked on me now? You know once a woman's been made love to by somebody who can really do it great! I was fantastic last night! I never once had to sit up and consult the manual. Love is very different for a woman. It's a complicated phenomenon. I don't know what to expect. I've never broken off with a woman before.

(*DREAM LIGHT. LINDA enters D. R. slot in trench coat, up R. steps to railing end.*)

LINDA. So you think it's as simple as that?

ALLAN. (*Up platform to LINDA.*) We have no choice.

LINDA. You told me you loved me.

ALLAN. Try to take it gracefully.

LINDA. But the time we spent together, the closeness, the promises.

ALLAN. Please, Linda . . .

LINDA. You mean too much to me. I can't let you go.

ALLAN. Linda, don't be difficult. . . . I'm sorry.

LINDA. Sorry's not enough . . . you think I'm a play toy.

ALLAN. What can I say?

LINDA. (*Bette Davis with gun.*) Give me the letter.

ALLAN. What letter?

LINDA. Philip, give me the letter. (*LINDA backs ALLAN up through all this.*)

ALLAN. There is no letter.

LINDA. I want the letter. Philip, give me the letter.

ALLAN. Linda, you're going crazy.

LINDA. You can't treat me that way.

ALLAN. Don't pull the trigger—I'm a bleeder. (*LIGHT FADES and she vanishes in R. C. slot. ALLAN crosses D. L. C.*) She'll kill me. Women are violence prone. Bette Davis, Barbara Stanwyck . . . they're killers . . . I'll go away.—I'll join the circus. I'll be a clown . . . I'll never take off my make-up . . . Like Jimmy Stewart.

(DREAM LIGHT. BOGART appears R. C. slot.)

BOGART. (At U. end of railing.) Pull yourself together, kid, you're hysterical.

ALLAN. I'm going to join the circus.

BOGART. You should feel encouraged. When you weren't coming on phony, you got a pretty good dame to fall for you. You never thought you could make it with dames. Well, you can.

ALLAN. But now it's got to end and I can't do it.

BOGART. It's not that hard, kid. Watch. (LINDA enters D. R. slot. MUSIC UNDER.) C'mere, sweetheart.

LINDA. (Up R. steps onto platform with BOGART.) Yes, darling?

BOGART. It's over.

LINDA. What is?

BOGART. Us.

LINDA. Over?

BOGART. That's right, toots. Over. Kaput.

LINDA. That simple, eh?

BOGART. That's right.

LINDA. Supposing I say no?

BOGART. Won't do you any good.

LINDA. (Pulls out pistol and sticks it in his face.) And will this?

BOGART. (Takes gun and slaps her in one cool move.) Come off it, Sugar. You never could use a rod.

LINDA. (Sobbing.) But why does it have to end before it can begin? Tell me why?

BOGART. You play too rough for me, Sugar. It was you that killed Johnson. Parker found out about it so you killed him too. But that wasn't good enough for you. You wanted to finish me off. You knew you couldn't do it while I was facing you so you figured you'd get me to turn my back. But not me, Sugar. Now come on. You're taking the fall. (LINDA exits, sobbing, D. R. slot.) That's all there is to it.

ALLAN. For you because you're Bogart.

check
music level

BOGART. Everybody is, kid. At certain times. You're doing something now I didn't think you had in you. You're passing up a real tomato because you don't want to hurt a guy. If I did that there wouldn't be a dry eye in the house.

ALLAN. Yeah, but I'm broken-hearted over it.

BOGART. That's all the more reason you can be proud of it.

ALLAN. You think so?

BOGART. Sure. Listen, kid, there's other things in life besides dames and one of 'em is to know you did a right thing for a pal. Think it over. (*BUZZ. He goes to door. It is LINDA. BOGART down steps R.*)

ALLAN. Er—grocery store not open yet?

LINDA. No.

BOGART. Tell her.

ALLAN. What?

BOGART. Tell her. Now. (*Exits D. R. slot.*)

ALLAN. Linda . . .

LINDA. Allan, do you realize what a wonderful thing has happened?

ALLAN. Linda—

LINDA. Allan, the most beautiful thing in the world has occurred right under our noses. We've had a wonderful experience. Doesn't that surprise you? You didn't have to do anything. Didn't have to leave any half-open books lying around . . . you didn't have to put on the proper mood music. I even saw you in your underwear with the days of the week written on them.

ALLAN. Look, Linda, we've . . . got to call it quits.

LINDA. Yes, I know. While I was out suddenly everything became very clear, and when I asked myself do I really want to break up my marriage . . . the answer was no. I love Dick, and while someone as wonderful as you is very tempting . . . I can't think of my life without him.

ALLAN. You can't?

LINDA. He needs me, Allan . . . and in some unexplainable way . . . I need him.

ALLAN. I know he needs you.

LINDA. This is the first time I've ever been affected by anyone besides Dick—I'm already a little in love with you—and unless I stop it now I'll find myself too deeply involved to go back to him. I don't regret one second of what's happened because what it's done for me is to reaffirm my feelings for Dick.

ALLAN. Go home, Linda. . . . He's home waiting for you.

LINDA. He is?

ALLAN. He came by while you were out. He wants you to go back to Cleveland with him. He'll explain it. Meanwhile, we'll just be good friends . . . I think I'd like that.

LINDA. You're sure? You're not saying that to make things easy?

ALLAN. (*PIANO MUSIC under starts.*) I'm saying it because it's true. Inside of us we both know you belong with Dick. (*MUSIC.*) You're part of his work, the thing that keeps him going. If that plane leaves the ground and you're not with him, you'll regret it. Maybe not today, maybe not tomorrow, but soon and for the rest of your life.

LINDA. That's beautiful.

ALLAN. It's from "Casablanca." I waited my whole life to say it.

LINDA. (*Up L. steps, kisses ALLAN.*) Goodbye. (*Exits.*)

NANCY. (*Enters U. L. slot.*) Poor Allan—I told you this would happen.

ALLAN. (*Crosses D. steps L. to sofa R.*) Are you kidding? She was in love with me—you heard her.

NANCY. *Meanwhile she's back with Dick.*

ALLAN. I gave him a pretty good run for his money . . . without even trying—that's the key.

BOGART. (*Enters U. R. C. slot.*) You tell her, kid—it's all yours now.

ALLAN. I'm going to do something I should have done a long time ago. I'm going to forget you.

Light
NANCY. What! Allan, don't—no—don't—don't nooo . . . (A long wail as she backs out U. L. slot.)

BOGART. Gee, kid, that was great. I'd have slapped her around a little myself, but you've got your own style.

ALLAN. I do have a little style.

BOGART. Well, kid, so long.

ALLAN. You're leaving?

BOGART. You don't need me anymore. There's nothing I could show you you don't already know.

ALLAN. I guess that's right. The secret's not being you, it's being me. True, you're not too tall and kinda ugly. But I'm short enough and ugly enough to succeed by myself.

Spot
BOGART. Here's looking at you, kid. (Exits D. slot.)

(DOOR BUZZ. PIANO FADES. ALLAN opens door.)

BARBARA. I'm sorry for bothering you. My name is Barbara Tyler. I just moved in upstairs and I'm all alone and I locked myself out. Could I use your phone?

ALLAN. Sure, it's right over there.

BARBARA. Thank you. (Noticing Film Quarterly on desk.) Film Quarterly! You're not the Allan Felix who writes for Film Quarterly, are you?

ALLAN. Yes, I am.

BARBARA. I just did my Ph.D. on "^{Film}Cinema" for the New School, and I used some of your articles for reference. They're very clever.

ALLAN. (PIANO MUSIC starts.) Thank you.

BARBARA. I particularly liked the article you wrote on "The African Queen."

ALLAN. That was one of my favorite movies.

BARBARA. It was quite a departure for Bogart.

ALLAN. Well, you see the thing about Bogart that most people don't know is that . . .

CURTAIN